

World History of Music - History of Arabian Music: A Study

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Habib Hassan Touma

World History of Music – History of Arabian Music: A Study

Preamble

The aim of writing a history of Arabian music should be to procure for the reader as complete an aesthetic knowledge of the music of the Arabs as possible. Written history should be complemented with audiovisual documentation i. e. phonographic discs, videotapes or films.

To establish an aesthetic knowledge of Arabian music, Arabian music needs first to be defined:

Historically, it is that music which was first developed in the Arab Peninsula in pre-Islamic times, continued to develop during the Islamic era and had its schools and centres in Mecca and Medinah (632 – 850 A. D.: Ancient classical music tradition); in Baghdad and Cordoba (820 – 1258 and 1492: Revival of the ancient classical music tradition); and thereafter had its centres scattered all over the Middle East and North Africa from the 13th century up to our modern times.

Empirically, it is the music listened to, performed and enjoyed by those who call it Arabian, namely the Arabs themselves and their neighbours the Turks, the Iranians, the religious and ethnic minorities living with the Arabs as well as the Ethiopians and African people bordering Arab countries in West and North Africa. Arabs are not only those living in the Arab Peninsula, i. e. Saudi Arabia, but all those who live in an Arab state, speak Arabic and carry out an Arabian culture. Arabian culture itself is based on the Arabic language, Islam and tradition.

Musicologically, it is the music characterized by its tonal system, rhythmic-temporal organization, its modal structure, its musical instruments, its composed and improvised forms – instrumental as well as vocal – and through the social occasions on which it is performed, from which sophisticated and less sophisticated categories of sacred, secular and entertainment forms result.

In spite of their division into many states, the Arabs belong to one nation and have one musical culture.

Methods of investigation

The subject matter should be investigated in sections in the form of reports, pragmatically, analytically and comparatively:

1. 6th to the 13th century should be investigated simply by a report in one section

2. 13th up to the 20th century, or rather, the 20th century backwards as far as the sources allow an investigation, should be studied pragmatically in seven sections, each of which deals with one or more related region or musical landscape.

These musical landscapes are:

- a. Mauritania
 - b. Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya
 - c. Egypt
 - d. Sudan, Somalia
 - e. Syria, Lebanon, Palestine, Jordan
 - f. Irak
 - g. Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Gulf States, Oman
3. Musico-cultural interrelationship and influences of Arabian music (in the course of history) on its neighbours and vice versa should be investigated analytically and comparatively in four sections:
- a. Persia, Turkey: 6th – 13th century
 - b. Europe of the Middle Ages: Spain, Southern France
 - c. West Africa: Mali, Senegal, Niger, Nigeria: 13th – 19th century
 - d. Western musical cultures: 20th century

Sources

1. The living music itself
2. The musician
3. The instrument-maker
4. The song texts
5. The music scholar living in an Arab country
6. The manuscripts stored in Middle Eastern, European, North Indian, Central Asian, Soviet Russian and American museums and libraries.

While the more important manuscripts on Arabian music have already been published either in the original text or in a European language, data on points 1 to 5 mentioned above are still in some Arab countries a *tabula rasa*, for example in Mauritania, Sudan, Saudi Arabia, Yemen, the Gulf States, Oman, Libya and Jordan. In all other countries, i. e. Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Syria, Lebanon, Palestine and Irak, a musical research has been done by local scholars and foreigners. It is not enough only to know what and where the sources are, it is more a question of how to achieve the right information from the source so as to conclude facts worthy of being included in a history of Arabian music. Furthermore, the source should not only serve the investigator to set up ties between today's living Arabian

music and the music of past centuries of Arabian history, but to help the investigator to display the continuum of Arabian musical culture.

Contents

The extent of utilization of the existing sources mentioned above under "Sources" and their compilation depend primarily on how voluminous the publication on the subject matter is planned to be and within what period of time it must be accomplished. The contents of Arabian music history are extensible.

Section One

- a. Pre-Islamic period up to 632 A. D.
- b. Classical Old-Arabian music tradition: 632 – 850
- c. Renewal of the Old-Arabian classical tradition in Baghdad and Cordoba: 820 – 1258

Section Two – Section Eight *

- a. Era of slackening: 13th to 19th century
- b. Renaissance era: 19th century
- c. Preservation of the Arabian musical identity: 20th century

Section Nine

Musico-cultural interrelationships and influences

- a. 6th to 13th century:
 - 1. Persians, Turks, Syrians
 - 2. Europe of the Middle Ages: Spain, Southern France, Sicily, Byzantium
- b. 13th to 19th century:
 - 1. North India, Central Asia
 - 2. West Africa
- c. 20th century:

Western musical culture.

* Section Two: Mauritania

Section Three: Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia and Libya

Section Four: Egypt

Section Five: Sudan (eventually also Somalia)

Section Six: Syria, Lebanon, Palestine and Jordan

Section Seven: Irak

Section Eight: Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Gulf States, Oman.



A 13th-century miniature representing musicians from Baghdad

Each section from One to Eight must contain and deal with the following points according to this plan:

1. Cultural and economical background, an introduction
2. Tonal system and rhythmic-temporal structures: scales, modes, rhythmic formulae
3. Musical forms and modal structures, improvised and composed, secular and sacred, vocal and instrumental
4. Musical instruments and instrument-makers

5. The musician: social and cultural function – the education of the musician
6. Purpose and occasion of music-making.

Cultural and economic background

Since artistic productivity is closely connected with the economic circumstances of a specific period of history of an Arab region, an introduction on the economical situation of that region at that specific period is essential to help us understand why that period was or still is artistically rich or poor. It is the economic dependence or independence of a region in any time which was or is responsible for exchange, assimilation and taking of musical elements other than those peculiar to the Arabs, or marring those original Arabian musical concepts. Conceptualization on music was and still is directly affected by the economic situation of the community. Artistic productivity or austerity reflects an essential part of the cultural scene which also should be covered in the introduction.

Tonal system and rhythmic structures

The Arabian tonal system is one of the fundamental determinates of Arabian music. Arabian music is primarily identified through its tonal system. The octave is for example divided into more than 17 unequal notes which may extend to 24 notes. Already in the 9th century scholars were occupied with the problem of division and until our modern times theoreticians are still occupied with this problem. The Arabian scale has a long history starting with al-Mawsili (9th century), al-Kindi (9th century), al-Farabi (10th century), al-Urmawi (13th century), Meshaga (19th century) and many other scholars of the 20th century. The Arabian music theory distinguishes namely between major and minor whole tones, minor and major seconds, and a medial second which lies between a major and a minor second. The Arabian scale is a combination of intervals taken from the pool of the Arabian tonal system, the scale or rather the row chosen from the pool serves as a means for presenting a modal structure.

Scholars have also been active since the earliest times of Arabian cultural history with the problem of time division and its relations to the sung music. Like the tonal system, the rhythmic organization, the *iqā'* or *wazn*, an essential element of Arabian music, must be investigated extensively in every region during the course of history.

Musical forms and modal structures

Arabian music has always been transmitted orally from one generation to another and was never fixed graphically. Its graphic fixation contradicts its substance,

namely its modal structure which is based mainly on improvisation. The core of the model structure is the predetermined tonal-spatial structure of a certain *maqam* and the free rhythmic-temporal organization of the melodic line realizing a characteristic mood of the chosen *maqam*. A *maqam* is the presentation of a mood through a modal structure named after the chosen row from the pool of the tonal system. The composed categories are modal structures moulded in measured periods, the *wazn*, and can display a great deal of variants, variations and paraphrases. These facts present a problem to those who expect a history of music in the Western concept, i. e. a history of forms, their change and developments and history of those responsible for that change. It is impossible to render musical forms played and listened to during the 10th century, for example, in Baghdad. Under these circumstances, the history of musical form has to start with today's living music and an investigation can extend backwards into the 19th century. Otherwise one has to believe the hypotheses that today's forms are the same as those of past centuries, which might be right: The historian must in this case furnish the reader with convincing proofs. This could be accomplished, had there been a discipline of Arabian musicology. An investigation in this direction has been started and it is believed that a certain number of substantial, concrete facts have been established. This is the major problem to be tackled when writing a history of Arabian music.

Musical instruments and instrument-makers

Organology, classification, use and function of musical instruments as well as their migration from one region to the other should be investigated in each section. Construction, tuning and repertoire of each instrument or category of instruments should be discussed in detail. Social rank of an instrument should be fully explained as well as who plays a specific instrument: men, women, children, clergy, etc. and on what occasion i. e. secular, sacred, etc. Each section should be illustrated with photographs of musicians playing an instrument.

This subject matter will certainly give much space to the *ud* (lute), *nay* (flute), *qanun* (zither), *kamanja* (fiddle), *darabukka* (goblet-drum) and *riqq* (frame drum) as well as their related instruments or variants. Special place should be given to the making of instruments, their decoration and construction. Centres of musical instruments in Damascus, Baghdad, Cairo, Tunis, Rabat and Sanaa must be described. Problems of production, export/import, competition with non-Arabian instruments, role of the authorities in controlling, encouraging, or choking the instrument-making (industry) should be investigated and described in detail: For together with the musician, the music instrument-maker represents an essential source of the tradition.

The musician: social and cultural function – The education of the musician

A survey of the social music life of the Arabs during the course of their history clearly shows that the Arab musician has been primarily a singer from the earliest times, and still is today. The pre-Islamic period, music practice and music centered on the person of the songstress. Today, after over a thousand years of Arab history, music life is much the same as it was in the 9th century: It is still centered on the person of the singer. After the centuries-old predominance of vocal music, it is only during the past few years that concerts devoted solely to instrumental music, without any singer at all, have been held, at which the instrumentalist can transmit what is known as *tarab*, i. e. a real joy in listening to music, with his instrument alone. Work, biography, influences on musical life, function and social rank of the musician should be investigated in each section fully.

Music education, music schools and transmission of musical tradition should be described in detail. Music education presents a problem which cannot be separa-



Bahrain: djahlah players in a Fidjeri performance of the pearl divers

ted from the whole range of problems confronting Arab society. Although the subject matter of music education should be touched upon in each section, special care should be given to the 20th century, where the musician is quite at a loss as to what he ought to do in a society which is struggling to preserve its identity and has been grappling with the problems of reorientation since the end of the 19th century.

Curricula of music education on the elementary, secondary and tertiary levels should be investigated and described. Perhaps recommendations should be made.

Purpose and occasion of music-making

Where, when and why an Arab made music – and still does – should be described in detail, both on the secular and sacred levels with references to social contexts. The answer to where, why, when and especially what music an Arab makes leads to the classification of musical forms, and to clarification of the meaning of making music, and its beauty; hence the aesthetic criteria of the Arabs: Special care should be given to musical structure, meaning and beauty for each category of music as it is created in its social context.

Compiling of data

Data should be compiled by asking as many scholars as possible, who had already done research on Arabian music, to contribute to the project. According to their specialization, scholars should be asked to contribute articles or studies on specific subjects to fit into the main plan of the history proposed above under "Contents". Wherever needed, scholars should be encouraged and asked to investigate unexplored themes of the history. In all cases contributions must be paid for, perhaps per published line or page of the final publication.

A fact-finding trip to some Arab countries is indispensable. The facts to be collected concern the sources: the living music itself, the musician, the instrument-maker and scholars living in a given country. The countries to be visited are: Algeria, the Gulf States, Libya, Mauritania, Oman, Saudi Arabia, Sudan and Yemen, as well as Jordan and the Palestinian refugees.

Habib Hassan Touma

Universalgeschichte der Musik – Geschichte der arabischen Musik (Kurzfassung)

Die arabische Musik läßt sich historisch, empirisch und musikwissenschaftlich definieren. Obwohl die arabische Welt in viele Staaten aufgesplittet ist, besteht sie doch aus einem einzigen Volk mit einer eigenen Musikkultur.

Die Geschichte der arabischen Musik ist unter einem pragmatischen, analytischen und komparativen Blickwinkel zu betrachten; die Untersuchung sollte – in der Form eines Rechenschaftsberichtes – in neun Abschnitte gegliedert werden und folgende Elemente enthalten:

- a. Vorislamische Zeit bis zum Jahre 632 unserer Zeitrechnung
- b. Die klassische altarabische Musiktradition (632 – 850)
- c. Die Erneuerung der klassischen altarabischen Tradition in Bagdad und Cordoba (820 – 1258)
- d. Zeit des Verfalls (13. – 19. Jahrhundert)
- e. Die Renaissance (19. Jahrhundert)
- f. Die Bewahrung der musikalischen Identität der arabischen Welt (20. Jahrhundert).

Jeder Abschnitt muß – in der nachstehenden Reihenfolge – die folgenden Punkte enthalten und behandeln:

1. Kultureller und wirtschaftlicher Hintergrund – Einleitung
2. Tonsystem und rhythmisch-temporale Strukturen: Skalen, Tonarten, rhythmische Muster
3. Improvisierte und komponierte Musikformen und modale Strukturen im weltlichen und geistlichen, im vokalen und instrumentalen Bereich
4. Musikinstrumente und Instrumentenbauer
5. Der Musiker: soziale und kulturelle Funktion, Musikausbildung
6. Ziele und Anlässe des Musikvortrags.

Quellen für die arabische Musik sind: die lebendige Musik selbst, die Musiker und Instrumentenbauer, die Gesangstexte, die in den arabischen Ländern lebenden Musikwissenschaftler sowie die in den Museen und Bibliotheken des Nahen Ostens, Nordindiens, Zentralasiens, der Sowjetunion und Amerikas vorhandenen Musikautographen.

Um Material zusammenzutragen, sollten möglichst viele Fachleute, die bereits die arabische Musik erforscht haben, um ihre Mitwirkung gebeten werden.

Habib Hassan Touma

Histoire universelle de la musique – Histoire de la musique arabe (résumé)

On peut donner de la musique arabe des définitions historique, empirique et musicologique. Bien que divisé en de nombreux Etats, le monde arabe est une seule nation, ayant sa propre culture musicale.

Il convient d'étudier l'histoire de la musique arabe sous un angle pragmatique, analytique et comparatif, et de structurer cette étude sous la forme d'un compte rendu en neuf sections, comportant les éléments suivants:

- | | |
|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> a. La période pré-islamique, jusqu'en 632 de notre ère b. La tradition musicale arabe classique ancienne (632 – 850) c. Le renouveau de la tradition classique ancienne à Bagdad et Cordoue (820 – 1258) d. La période de fléchissement (13^e – 19^e siècle) e. La renaissance (19^e siècle) f. La préservation de l'identité musicale du monde arabe (20^e siècle). <p>Chaque section devra contenir et traiter les points suivants, dans l'ordre ci-dessous:</p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> 1. Fondements culturels et économiques – Introduction 2. Système tonal et structures temporelles-rythmiques: échelles, modes, formules rythmiques 3. Formes musicales et structures modales, improvisées et composées, séculaires et sacrées, vocales et instrumentales 4. Instruments de musique et ceux qui les fabriquent 5. Le musicien: fonction sociale et culturelle, formation du musicien 6. Objectifs et occasions de l'exécution. |
|---|---|

Les sources de la musique arabe sont: la musique vivante elle-même, le musicien, celui qui fabrique les instruments, les textes des chants, le chercheur vivant dans un pays arabe et les manuscrits gardés dans les musées et bibliothèques du Moyen-Orient, d'Europe, d'Inde du nord, d'Asie centrale, d'Union soviétique et d'Amérique.

Pour compiler les données, on pourrait faire appel à la collaboration du plus grand nombre possible de spécialistes ayant déjà mené des recherches sur la musique arabe.